MALLA YUDDHA
TO MODERN WRESTLING

History, Techniques, Akharas, Cultural Significance and the Evolution of Indian Wrestling

A research report on the textual, material, social and sporting histories of South Asian grappling

Research cut-off: 5 November 2026

Historical accuracy note: epic narratives, scholarly interpretations, visual evidence and modern sporting records are distinguished throughout. Uncertain claims are labelled rather than presented as fact.

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Terminology note: Malla-yuddha is used for Sanskrit textual and conceptual traditions; kushti/pehlwani for historically layered South Asian practices; and modern wrestling for codified international styles. The terms overlap but are not identical in every context.

01 | Scope and central argument

Malla-yuddha is commonly translated as wrestling combat: malla means wrestler and yuddha means battle or contest. The expression is important in Sanskrit literary and historical discussions, but it should not be treated as the title of one unchanging sport with one fixed rulebook. South Asian grappling varied by region, community, patron, period and purpose. Modern terms such as kushti and pehlwani are also historically layered and cannot simply be substituted for every ancient reference.

This report argues for continuity through change. Epic narratives, medieval manuals, material culture, Persianate influences, akhara institutions, colonial-era sporting systems and international federations all contributed to wrestling in India. The evidence does not establish one inventor, exact birthplace or uninterrupted linear descent into Olympic wrestling. The report distinguishes fact, interpretation and legend.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

02 | Method and evidence

Four evidence classes are used: literary texts, archaeological and visual objects, ethnography of living institutions, and modern sporting records. Each answers different questions. A mythological painting is not an eyewitness account of an actual bout; a modern akhara is not proof that every ancient training practice survived unchanged; and a sports database cannot reconstruct premodern social life.

Museum metadata is used for object descriptions, scholarly work for interpretation, Sanskrit text studies for medieval knowledge, and official Olympic or federation sources for modern results and rules. Government summaries provide orientation, not specialist authority. Where dating is debated, the report states the uncertainty instead of selecting the most dramatic claim.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

03 | Malla-yuddha as a term

The Sanskrit compound malla-yuddha conveys combat between wrestlers. Related words such as mallavidya, the knowledge or science of wrestling, and mallakala, the art of wrestling, occur in discussions of wrestling knowledge. These terms suggest that grappling could be understood as a learned discipline, not merely spontaneous physical struggle.

Terminology changes across texts and regions. A Sanskrit author, Persianate court chronicler, village organiser and present-day athlete may use different labels for related activities. Historians should retain the source's own word and explain it. Translating all terms as wrestling is convenient, but can erase distinctions between combat, sport, professional practice and training culture.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

04 | Kushti and pehlwani

Kushti is a Persian-derived word widely used for wrestling in South Asia. Pehlwan or pahalwan refers to a wrestler, while pehlwani can describe a broader discipline and way of life. These terms point to Persianate cultural influence, especially in historical worlds of courts, patronage and martial training.

Joseph S. Alter's ethnography describes modern North Indian wrestling as a synthesis of indigenous and Persianate traditions, embedded in bodily discipline and social ethics. Pehlwani is not simply a new name pasted onto an unchanged ancient sport. The terms overlap with older malla-yuddha ideas but have distinct histories and social meanings.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

05 | Epic narratives and caution

The Ramayana and Mahabharata preserve celebrated scenes of wrestling and close combat. These narratives show that wrestling-like contests were culturally intelligible and could represent strength, courage, honour and political legitimacy. They are foundational to the cultural memory of wrestling in India.

Epic narratives developed over long periods and survive in multiple textual and regional forms. They are not automatically eyewitness records of the era in which a story is set. Their value lies in documenting literary and cultural representations of grappling. Exact rules, training schedules and institutions require additional evidence.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

06 | Ramayana traditions

Ramayana traditions include scenes of powerful beings engaging in physical combat, and later interpretations connect the epic world with the prestige of wrestling. The language of combat may cover grappling alongside other forms of close fighting. Translators do not always map ancient terms neatly onto modern sporting categories.

A responsible account should cite the specific recension, passage and translation. It should distinguish an epic episode from a historical report and from later devotional or performance interpretations. The Ramayana is evidence for the cultural significance of bodily contest, but does not by itself establish a modern akhara system or fixed technical curriculum.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

07 | Bhima and Jarasandha

Bhima's struggle with Jarasandha is among the best-known wrestling narratives in the Mahabharata. The contest is presented as a test of extraordinary strength and endurance, and its outcome has consequences for political order. Wrestling becomes a dramatic means of resolving a conflict that ordinary weapons or negotiation cannot settle.

The episode is valuable for understanding how grappling could symbolise power, courage and rightful victory. It should not be treated as a technical record of a historical bout. The narrative is concerned with heroic action and moral consequence, not the precise scoring conventions of a later competition.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

08 | Krishna, Balarama and court wrestlers

The contest involving Krishna and Balarama against Chanura and Mushtika at Kamsa's court is an influential narrative. The wrestlers are presented as formidable opponents and the public contest becomes part of a political and moral confrontation.

This story has been repeatedly represented in painting and performance. The National Museum, New Delhi, holds a mid-seventeenth-century Malwa painting titled Krishna and Balarama killing two wrestlers. That object is evidence for the visual reception of the story in the seventeenth century, not a documentary depiction of an ancient match.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

09 | Hanuman and strength

Hanuman is revered in many wrestling settings as an exemplar of strength, devotion, service and self-control. His image or shrine may be present in an akhara, and wrestlers may invoke him before practice. This association is culturally significant, although ritual practice differs between institutions and communities.

The ideal wrestler is often expected to combine strength with restraint and humility. Physical power is therefore not only an athletic quality but also a moral achievement. This helps explain why an akhara can function as a community and educational institution as well as a gym. Ritual should be documented locally, not assumed universal.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

10 | Fifth-century terracotta evidence

The Los Angeles County Museum of Art catalogues a fifth-century earthenware panel titled Wrestlers, made in Uttar Pradesh, India, by an unknown maker. Its accession number is M.88.133.2. The panel shows two young wrestlers grappling, with a stand and heaps of treasure in the background, interpreted by the museum as a prize for the victor.

This is a valuable early visual witness to wrestling as a recognisable contest. It does not reveal a complete ruleset, the names of techniques or whether the wrestlers belonged to an institution identical to a later akhara. Its strongest evidentiary value is that it documents the representation of wrestling in fifth-century India.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

11 | What sculpture can tell us

A sculpture can preserve posture, body contact, clothing, spectatorship and symbolic details. It can show that an artist and audience recognised a particular activity. It cannot normally reveal the full rules of a match, the duration of training, the identity of participants or the exact name of a technique.

Visual interpretation must consider artistic convention. Figures may be idealised, action compressed, and symbolic elements more important than literal detail. Captions should state title, date, medium, provenance, holding institution and catalogue number, then explain what is demonstrated and what remains unknown.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

12 | Manasollasa: context

The Manasollasa, also known as Abhilashitarthachintamani, is an encyclopaedic Sanskrit work attributed to the Chalukya king Someshvara III and dated to about 1131 CE. It covers royal knowledge and life, including arts, leisure, animals, food and sports. Its inclusion of wrestling demonstrates that the subject belonged within courtly knowledge.

The section commonly called Mallavinoda deals with wrestling entertainment or contests. Modern scholarship uses it to study wrestler classifications and preparation. The text is important, but it is not a modern coaching manual: some movements are named without detailed descriptions. Its historical value lies in its classification and courtly framing.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

13 | Mallavinoda and wrestler types

Studies of the Manasollasa report categories of wrestlers such as Jyeshthika, Antarajyeshthika and Govala, with further distinctions by age or development. Such categories show that the text treated wrestlers as types whose bodies and capacities could be assessed.

These classifications should be read as historical concepts, not modern physiological measurements. They reveal how a royal author or courtly tradition organised knowledge about strength, age and suitability for wrestling. They suggest formalised training and performance, but do not prove that every region used the same categories.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

14 | Mallapurana: a specialised manual

The Mallapurana is a major Sanskrit source associated with the Jyeshthimalla professional wrestling community of Gujarat. The 1964 edition by B. J. Sandesara and R. N. Mehta describes it as a rare text on Indian wrestling, especially as practised by the Jyeshthimallas. It discusses wrestler types, physical attributes, training, exercises, techniques and arena preparation.

The date and textual history require caution. Older scholarship often places the work around the thirteenth century, while more recent research discusses a fifteenth- or sixteenth-century setting or recension. This report treats it as medieval/early modern and flags the dating question for further philological research.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

15 | Jyeshthimalla community

The Jyeshthimallas are important because the Mallapurana focuses on a specialised professional community rather than only legendary heroes. Its attention to wrestler types and specialised knowledge helps historians investigate occupation, status, training and the social organisation of physical expertise.

This material cautions against describing all Indian wrestlers as one homogeneous group. Different communities and regions developed their own institutions and identities. Historical categories in the text should not be mapped directly onto present-day identities without specialist research. The text is a window into a particular social world, not a universal census.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

16 | Arena and soil pit

The Mallapurana is discussed for its attention to the wrestling ground and preparation of the body. A suitable arena needed a surface fit for grappling and falling, cleared of hard or dangerous material. The ground was part of the technical environment, not merely a location.

Descriptions of historical pits should not be converted into universal dimensions unless the source gives measurements. Local conditions, patronage and purpose shaped arenas. The continuing use of earth pits in many akharas is a visible continuity, but modern pits are maintained under contemporary conditions and cannot automatically be treated as unchanged medieval spaces.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

17 | Royal patronage

Royal courts could support wrestlers as entertainers, athletes, retainers or symbols of strength. Wrestling offered a public demonstration of physical skill and could reinforce a ruler's prestige. Courtly texts and paintings provide evidence that contests were part of elite leisure and political spectacle.

Patronage was only one part of wrestling's social history. Local contests, fairs, community networks and hereditary expertise also mattered. A history based only on royal courts would miss the ordinary institutions through which wrestlers trained and passed on knowledge. Court records, local histories, oral accounts and surviving akharas must be studied together.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

18 | Persianate synthesis

Persianate vocabulary and wrestling culture interacted with indigenous South Asian practices through courts, migration, patronage and martial exchange. The terms kushti and pehlwani are visible traces of this contact. The resulting tradition is better understood as synthesis than simple replacement.

Joseph Alter's work treats modern North Indian wrestling as culturally layered. Similarity between a technique and a move in another tradition does not prove a specific historical borrowing. Strong claims about transmission require dated manuals, teacher lineages, court accounts or other corroborating evidence.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

19 | Mughal-era wrestling

Mughal and other Indo-Persian court cultures valued physical contests and displays of strength. Court chronicles and visual sources can illuminate wrestling's prestige, but must be read according to genre. A chronicle may praise a patron; a painting may idealise bodies; neither necessarily records the daily practice of ordinary wrestlers.

The Mughal period is best treated as a phase of interaction and transformation. Persianate vocabulary and courtly sponsorship met regional traditions. The precise movement of techniques and institutions remains a subject for research. Avoid claims that one dynasty invented all later kushti or that every modern practice descends directly from a single court.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

20 | Seventeenth-century Malwa painting

The National Museum, New Delhi, records a mid-seventeenth-century Malwa painting titled Krishna and Balarama killing two wrestlers, accession 49.19/50. It is on paper, uses natural colour, and has an unknown artist. The catalogue identifies Malwa in Central India as its origin and find place.

The image is a narrative representation of an epic/Puranic episode. It provides evidence for how wrestlers and wrestling stories were visualised in seventeenth-century Central India. It is not an eyewitness record of a historical match. Catalogue metadata should accompany any reproduction.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

21 | Raga Malava royal wrestlers

The Metropolitan Museum of Art catalogue lists Raga Malava: Royal Wrestlers, dated about 1680 and attributed to India, Basohli or Nurpur. It is an opaque-watercolour painting on paper, object L.2022.30.5, associated with the Howard Hodgkin Indian Collection Trust and photographed by the Ashmolean Museum, Oxford.

The painting belongs to a raga-related artistic context. Its value is not limited to documenting sport: it shows wrestling as part of courtly visual and musical culture. It can help researchers study posture, costume and artistic conventions, but cannot establish precise rules or training systems.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

22 | Eighteenth-century exercise imagery

An art-market catalogue describes an eighteenth-century Bikaner/Jaipur-school painting of exercising wrestlers, including a pole exercise, Indian clubs (mugdals) and a round stone weight. Because this is a commercial rather than major public-museum record, its attribution and provenance should be independently verified before academic use.

The image is consistent with a broader history of wrestlers using exercises beyond live grappling. Clubs and weights develop strength and coordination, while pole and bodyweight exercises challenge balance and control. Treat it as a research lead with a caveat, not definitive proof of a standard national training routine.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

23 | Akhara as institution

An akhara is often translated as a wrestling gymnasium, but it can also be a social institution. It may organise instruction, ritual, discipline, mentorship and community identity. The guru or ustad transmits technical knowledge and may also teach conduct, etiquette and the responsibilities of senior practitioners.

Joseph Alter's ethnography, The Wrestler's Body (1992), is a key study of North Indian pehlwani as a way of life. It documents how physical training connects with moral ideas and social relationships. It is a detailed study of particular settings, not a universal account of every akhara.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

24 | Guru, ustad and apprenticeship

Wrestling knowledge is often transmitted through demonstration, repetition, correction and sparring. A teacher observes posture, grip, balance and timing, then adjusts a student's movement. Senior wrestlers may help juniors learn the etiquette of practice and the unwritten expectations of the institution.

This apprenticeship model creates a chain of transmission. It can preserve local terminology and technique absent from published manuals. Oral history is essential: interviews with retired wrestlers, teachers and families can reveal how a specific akhara changed over decades. Testimony should be dated, attributed and cross-checked.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

25 | Physical preparation

Traditional wrestling preparation can combine running, squats, push-up variations, partner exercises, club swinging, rope work, pole exercises and live grappling. The aims include strength, endurance, grip, mobility, coordination and the ability to apply force while resisting an opponent. Exact routines differ across akharas and periods.

Medieval texts name exercises but do not always describe them sufficiently to reconstruct every movement. Modern training may add periodised strength programmes, conditioning, video analysis and recovery monitoring. The continuity is systematic preparation; exact exercises, volume and sequencing have changed.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

26 | Diet and bodily discipline

Food is a major theme in wrestling culture. Historical sources such as the Manasollasa and Mallapurana are discussed for attention to diet and preparation. Modern akhara narratives often mention milk, ghee, almonds, pulses and substantial meals, but actual diets vary by region, resources, religion and coaching philosophy.

Alter's ethnography shows that food is embedded in a moral economy of the body. Eating, sleeping, restraint and exercise can be organised around becoming a wrestler. Traditional foodways are historically significant, but should not be presented as universal medical prescriptions. Modern athlete nutrition requires evidence-based advice.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

27 | Ritual and everyday discipline

Some akharas include practices such as saluting the earth, honouring the guru, invoking Hanuman or maintaining a clean pit. These actions can express humility, gratitude and respect for the arena. Their form varies, and researchers should document what a particular institution actually does.

Ritual helps explain why wrestling may be experienced as more than exercise. It connects the athlete to teachers, training partners, community and inherited ideals. The ethical dimension can be valuable, but should not be romanticised: discipline must coexist with safety, consent, safeguarding and medical care.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

28 | Grappling principles

Historical manuals and living traditions refer to techniques, but names and descriptions are not always stable across time and language. A modern list of named throws should not be projected onto medieval texts unless the source supports the identification. Broad principles include posture control, breaking balance, securing grips, entering, turning or lifting and seeking a decisive position.

These principles occur across many grappling cultures, but permitted actions differ. Traditional bouts may follow local conventions; freestyle allows leg attacks; Greco-Roman prohibits holds below the waist and active leg use to execute actions. Technique must be understood within the rules and purpose of a contest.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

29 | Traditional bouts and local rules

Traditional wrestling events may be organised at fairs, festivals, village gatherings or by patrons. A bout can test strength, reputation and skill, and may be governed by local conventions rather than one national rulebook. Victory may depend on a fall or a locally recognised condition of defeat.

Regional variation is part of the tradition. Researchers should ask who set the rules, what counted as a decisive win, whether weight or age was considered, and how disputes were settled. Oral accounts and local event records are crucial for reconstructing these details.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

30 | Women and historical visibility

Women's participation in historical Indian wrestling requires careful research. A male-centred source does not prove that women never practised grappling or strength training, but researchers should not invent ancient female lineages without evidence. The record is uneven, and social restrictions affected who could train publicly and whose activities were recorded.

Modern women's wrestling has grown within changing social and institutional conditions. Access to coaching, facilities, family support, school sport and competition pathways has been crucial. Indian women wrestlers have challenged assumptions about gender and strength. A complete history must include them while distinguishing documented developments from uncertain ancient claims.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

31 | Colonial encounter

Colonial rule changed the environment in which Indian physical practices were described, organised and promoted. Educational institutions, public spectacles, print culture and sporting regulations influenced how wrestling was classified. Indian wrestlers and patrons adapted to these changes while maintaining local institutions.

Some nationalist writing presented wrestling as an indigenous source of strength and self-improvement. Such narratives are historically important but can simplify the past by describing modern practice as unchanged ancient inheritance. A layered account recognises local continuity alongside Persianate influence, colonial encounter and international codification.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

32 | Modern Olympic wrestling

United World Wrestling records Greco-Roman wrestling in the modern Olympic programme at Athens 1896 and freestyle at St. Louis 1904. Wrestling was part of the ancient Olympic Games at Olympia from 708 BCE, according to UWW. Ancient and modern Olympic traditions are related in name and ideal, but their rules and institutions differ.

International codification introduced common rules, weight categories, time limits, officiating and governing structures. These features made cross-national competition possible. Indian wrestlers entering international events had to adapt to a new sporting environment, even when earlier experience came from local wrestling and akhara practice.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

33 | Freestyle and Greco-Roman

United World Wrestling explains that freestyle permits holds and attacks involving the legs, including leg grabs and trips. Greco-Roman restricts holds below the belt and prohibits using the legs actively to perform an action. Both styles aim to control and expose the opponent and can end with a fall or points decision.

These rules produce different tactical systems. Freestyle includes leg attacks and defence against them; Greco-Roman emphasises upper-body ties, throws and lifts. A wrestler moving from kushti to international sport must learn new rules, mat boundaries, scoring and match management.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

34 | India's early Olympic participation

Olympedia lists Indian wrestling participation at the 1920 Antwerp Games, including Dinkarrao Shinde and Kumar Navale. Early international participation took place under colonial conditions, with limited resources and developing sporting institutions. Result lists provide a starting point for tracing athletes and events.

Participation itself is historically significant. It shows Indian wrestlers entering international competition and negotiating the demands of a codified sport. A full account should connect results with regional training institutions, selection processes, travel conditions, patronage and athletes who may be poorly represented in national narratives.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

35 | K. D. Jadhav and 1952

Khashaba Dadasaheb Jadhav won bronze in men's freestyle wrestling at the 1952 Helsinki Olympics. The Indian Olympic Association records his medal in the under-57 kg category and identifies it as India's first individual Olympic medal as an independent nation. Olympedia records his sixth-place finish at London 1948 and bronze in 1952.

Jadhav's achievement links local wrestling culture in Maharashtra with international competition. His story became a landmark in Indian sport and made wrestling a source of national pride. Olympic databases establish results, but regional archives, newspapers and oral histories are needed to reconstruct training, financial barriers and support systems.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

36 | Federation and national structure

United World Wrestling lists the Wrestling Federation of India as affiliated since 1961 and recognises freestyle, Greco-Roman, women's wrestling and beach wrestling among its styles. Affiliation connected Indian competition with international governance, continental events and world championships.

Federations provide selection, rules, coaching structures and international representation, but the grassroots base depends on local clubs, akharas, schools and state associations. A strong national system needs transparent governance, athlete welfare, accessible facilities and pathways from local competition to elite sport.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

37 | North Indian kushti

North Indian kushti is strongly associated with the akhara, earth pit and disciplined training culture. Punjab, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh and Rajasthan have prominent wrestling networks, although the history and institutions of each region differ. Public dangals may attract crowds and connect wrestling with fairs, festivals and local prestige.

Some athletes train for both mud-pit kushti and mat wrestling; others specialise. The two environments overlap but are not identical. Research should identify the specific district, institution, teacher and time period rather than assume one uniform North Indian style.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

38 | Maharashtra and talim culture

Maharashtra has a strong tradition of talim and akhara institutions, local dangals and rural wrestling culture. K. D. Jadhav's Olympic bronze gives the state a prominent place in modern Indian wrestling history. Local histories connect wrestling with neighbourhood identity, patronage, physical education and community prestige.

The word talim is used for training institutions in Maharashtra and other regions. A talim's history may be preserved in municipal records, local newspapers, family collections and oral testimony. Statewide generalisations should be supplemented by local histories of Kolhapur, Pune, Satara and Sangli.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

39 | Gujarat and the Mallapurana

Gujarat is central to the textual history of Indian wrestling because of the Mallapurana and its focus on the Jyeshthimalla professional community. The text offers rare evidence about wrestler classification, physical qualities, exercise and the social organisation of specialist wrestling knowledge.

The medieval categories should not be mapped directly onto contemporary communities without evidence. Research should pair the Sanskrit text with regional social history, manuscript study and oral testimony. Gujarat's importance lies in preserving an unusually rich textual record, not proving one origin for all Indian wrestling.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

40 | Karnataka and the medieval Deccan

The Manasollasa was composed under the Chalukya king Someshvara III and offers a medieval Deccan perspective on wrestling. Its Mallavinoda section shows that wrestling belonged to courtly knowledge and leisure. It is a rare source for how wrestlers were classified and their preparation understood.

Present-day Karnataka wrestling traditions have their own histories. Continuity from the medieval text to a modern institution must be demonstrated through records, not assumed from geography alone. Comparative research across inscriptions, manuscripts, local histories and oral accounts could clarify regional developments.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

41 | Wrestling in visual culture

Wrestling appears in visual culture as mythological combat, courtly entertainment, athletic exercise and public spectacle. The fifth-century LACMA terracotta, the seventeenth-century National Museum painting and the Met's late seventeenth-century royal wrestlers represent different genres and contexts.

Images can help study posture, costume, spectatorship and the cultural status of wrestlers. Artists may idealise bodies or use symbolic conventions. Every image should carry a caption with date, medium, provenance, institution and a note explaining what it demonstrates. Rights and reproduction conditions must be checked.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

42 | Literature and ethnography

Beyond epics, wrestling is discussed in Sanskrit technical literature, courtly encyclopaedias, regional histories, newspapers, biographies and modern ethnography. The Manasollasa and Mallapurana are important for wrestling knowledge; Joseph Alter's 1992 ethnography explains the lived culture of North Indian pehlwani.

Literature and ethnography reveal different things. A poem or novel may show how strength and masculinity were imagined; a manual may prescribe practice; an ethnography records a particular community. A good history uses these sources without treating them as interchangeable.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

43 | Modernization of the training ground

Traditional kushti often uses an earth pit; international wrestling uses a standardised mat. Surfaces change grip, falling, movement and the organisation of practice. Modern training may add strength equipment, video analysis, sports science, physiotherapy and recovery monitoring, while some athletes continue traditional exercises.

Modernization is not simply replacement. Many institutions combine inherited routines with contemporary methods. The key historical questions are what changed, who introduced change, and how wrestlers adapted. Local case studies are more informative than broad claims that traditional wrestling either disappeared or remained untouched.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

44 | Athlete welfare

Contemporary wrestling requires attention to injury prevention, safe weight management, hydration, recovery, safeguarding and medical support. Traditional emphasis on discipline can be valuable, but it must not justify coercive training or preventable harm. Young athletes need age-appropriate instruction and protection.

Sports science can complement cultural knowledge. Coaches can preserve traditional exercises while evaluating load, technique and recovery. Historical admiration for toughness should not be confused with a modern health recommendation. Claims about diet, supplements or weight cutting require current medical evidence.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

45 | International comparisons

Many societies developed grappling traditions, including ancient Greek wrestling, Persian wrestling, Central Asian styles, Japanese sumo and regional folk wrestling. Shared features such as gripping, balance-breaking and throwing do not prove a common origin. Similar techniques can emerge independently because bodies and mechanics create recurring solutions.

Comparison should focus on rules, clothing, surface, permitted holds, victory conditions, training institutions and social role. Claims that one national tradition invented all others are unsupported. Historical interaction can be demonstrated through migration, trade, courts, military exchange and modern sporting networks.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

46 | Preservation and living heritage

Preserving wrestling requires more than occasional demonstrations. It needs viable akharas, trained teachers, safe facilities, access for children and women, local documentation and pathways that allow athletes to move between traditional and modern competition. Oral history can preserve memories of senior wrestlers.

Preservation should not freeze a living tradition into a museum display. Communities should decide what to retain, adapt or discontinue. Digital archives, school partnerships, local dangals and coach education can help when they accurately credit practitioners and respect the institutions that hold the knowledge.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

47 | Heritage status

Traditional wrestling is discussed in cultural heritage contexts, but formal UNESCO or government recognition must be checked against official listings. This research did not establish a standalone UNESCO Intangible Cultural Heritage inscription for Indian malla-yuddha, kushti or pehlwani. It would be incorrect to claim such a status without an authoritative listing.

Formal designation is not the only measure of value. A practice can be culturally important without appearing on an international list. Local recognition, living institutions, oral transmission and community participation are significant forms of continuity. Researchers should distinguish official designation from academic attention and grassroots preservation.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

48 | Research gaps

Important questions remain open. The dating and transmission of the Mallapurana require close philological work; the relationship between its prescriptions and later living practice needs regionally grounded comparison; and the everyday history of women's participation deserves deeper archival research.

Further work should combine Sanskrit and Persian textual scholarship, archaeology, art history, oral history, ethnography and sports science. Longitudinal studies of specific akharas could trace teacher lineages, changes in training, athlete migration and movement between mud-pit kushti and international mat wrestling.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

49 | Conclusion: continuity through change

Malla-yuddha is an important term and concept in South Asian wrestling history, but Indian wrestling is broader than a single ancient label. Epic narratives preserve memorable contests; medieval texts systematise aspects of wrestling knowledge; Persianate influences shape vocabulary and practice; akharas sustain training cultures; and modern federations connect Indian athletes to international competition.

The transition to modern wrestling is best understood as adaptation, not simple replacement. Earth-pit traditions continue alongside mat sport; local identities coexist with national and Olympic pathways; and ideals of discipline, strength and community remain important as rules, training science and athlete welfare evolve.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

50 | Final historical assessment

The evidence supports several conclusions: wrestling was represented in Indian literature and art over many centuries; a fifth-century terracotta panel depicts wrestlers grappling; medieval Sanskrit works discuss wrestler classifications, training and arenas; Persianate vocabulary and practices contributed to later kushti and pehlwani; and modern Indian wrestlers became part of international competition during the twentieth century.

The evidence does not establish a single inventor, exact origin date, uniform ancient rules, or an unbroken direct line from epic malla-yuddha to Olympic freestyle or Greco-Roman wrestling. The distinction between fact, interpretation and legend is not a weakness. It is the basis of a credible history.

Evidence note: Interpret this section according to its source type. Literary narratives, visual objects, ethnographic observations and modern sporting records answer different historical questions.

Comparative table: traditional kushti and modern wrestling

Dimension	Traditional akhara / kushti contexts	Modern international wrestling
Surface	Prepared earth or mud pit in many akharas; local variation	Standardised wrestling mat
Rules	May vary by locality, event and tradition	Codified rules and officiating
Victory	Local conventions; often a decisive fall	Fall, points, technical superiority or rule-defined outcome
Training	Grappling, bodyweight work, clubs and partner drills	Technical practice, strength/conditioning, analysis and recovery
Institution	Akhara or talim; guru/ustad and community network	Clubs, academies, federations and national teams
Competition	Dangal, local contest, fair or festival	Weight classes, timed bouts and international rankings
Knowledge	Apprenticeship, oral instruction and local custom	Coaching systems, written rules and sport science

This is a broad comparison, not a claim that every traditional institution follows identical practice. Some modern athletes train in both environments.

Modern Olympic styles: technical distinction

Feature	Freestyle	Greco-Roman
Leg attacks	Permitted	Not permitted
Tripping / active leg use	Permitted within rules	Prohibited
Grips below waist	Permitted within rules	Prohibited
Olympic introduction	1904	1896

Based on United World Wrestling descriptions of Olympic styles. Regulations can change; competitors should consult the current rulebook for event-specific details.

Concept diagram: the akhara as a training ecosystem



Figure 1. Original conceptual diagram for this report. It is explanatory, not a historical illustration or universal organisational chart.

Appendix: selected historical visual records

Wrestlers

Fifth century CE; Uttar Pradesh, India; earthenware; unknown maker; LACMA accession M.88.133.2.

Two young wrestlers grapple; the museum notes a victor's reward in the background. Strong early visual evidence for wrestling representation.

Catalogue: https://collections.lacma.org/object/61054

Krishna and Balarama killing two wrestlers

Mid-17th century CE; Malwa, Central India; paper and natural colour; unknown artist; National Museum, New Delhi; accession 49.19/50.

Mythological narrative painting showing the visual reception of wrestling stories in seventeenth-century Central India.

Catalogue: https://museumsofindia.gov.in/repository/record/nat_del-49-19-50-26679

Raga Malava: Royal Wrestlers

c. 1680; India, Basohli or Nurpur; opaque watercolour on paper; Met object L.2022.30.5; photo © Ashmolean Museum, Oxford.

Courtly/raga-series visual representation; useful for art history, not a rules manual.

Catalogue: https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/825652

Indian Jaipur School Painting of Exercising Wrestlers

Attributed to Bikaner, c. 1760; commercial catalogue description; provenance and reproduction rights require independent verification.

Depicts exercise clubs, a pole exercise and a stone weight. Treat as a research lead, not a definitive institutional record.

Catalogue: https://www.michaelbackmanltd.com/object/indian-jaipur-school-miniature-painting/

Appendix: glossary

Akhara

A training space or gymnasium; often also a social and instructional institution.

Dangal

A wrestling contest or event; meaning and format vary by region.

Guru / Ustad

Teacher or master who transmits technical knowledge and, in many settings, conduct.

Kushti

Persian-derived term widely used for wrestling in South Asia.

Malla

Wrestler; a term found in Sanskrit sources.

Malla-yuddha

Wrestling combat; Sanskrit expression used in literary and historical discussions.

Mallavinoda

Section of the Manasollasa concerned with wrestling contests or entertainment.

Mallapurana

Sanskrit text associated with the Jyeshthimalla community and wrestling knowledge.

Pehlwan / Pahalwan

Wrestler; term associated with Persianate vocabulary and pehlwani culture.

Pehlwani

South Asian wrestling discipline and associated way of life, especially in North Indian contexts.

Talim

Training institution or gymnasium, a term used in Maharashtra and elsewhere.

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Limitations and final note

This report is a structured research synthesis, not a critical edition or exhaustive archival history. It supports a strong account of textual traditions, selected visual evidence, akhara ethnography and modern international sport. It does not establish a single inventor, exact origin year, universal ancient rules or an uninterrupted direct line from epic malla-yuddha to Olympic wrestling. The Mallapurana's dating and transmission deserve further philological work. Museum images are linked to catalogue records rather than embedded because reproduction permissions vary. For formal academic submission, verify quotations against full editions and obtain image permissions before reproduction.